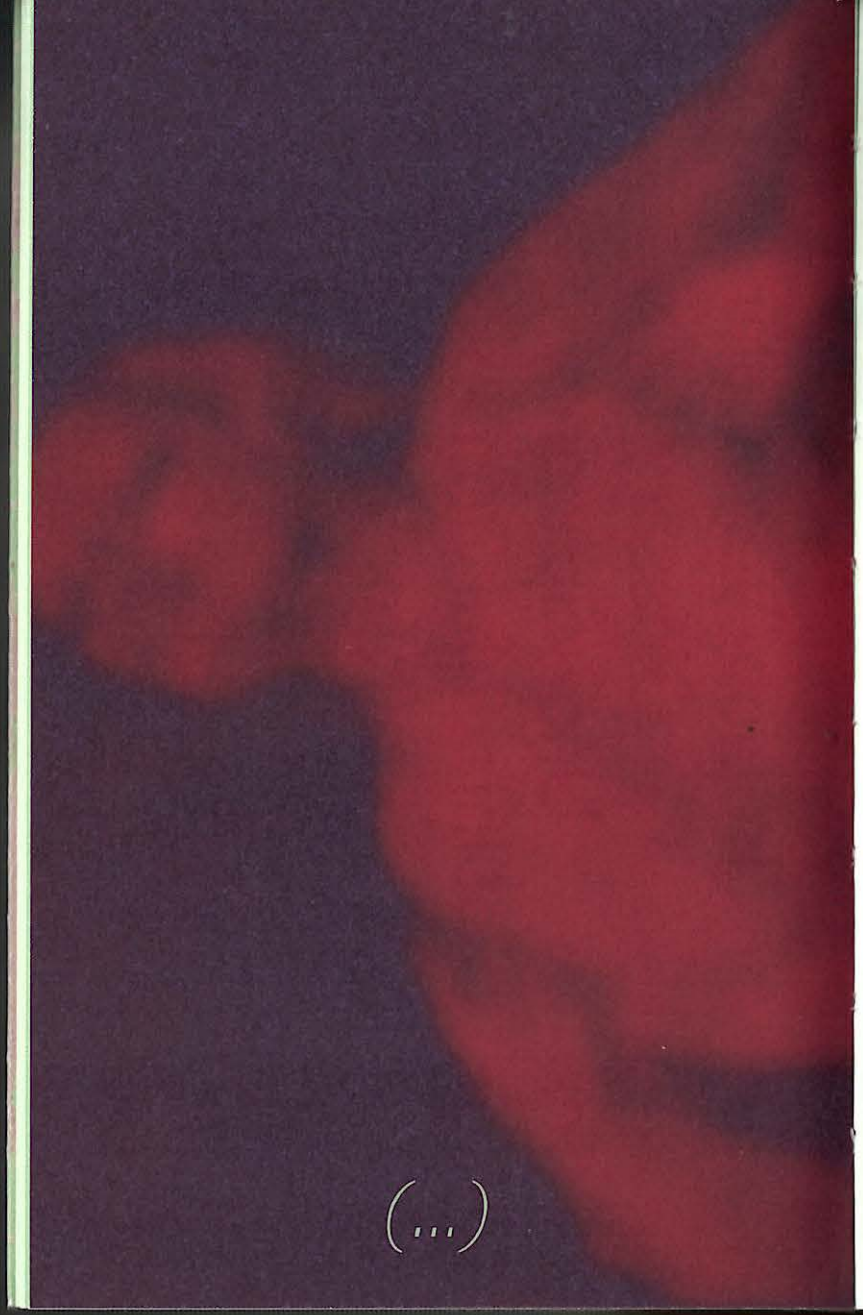
Glossary of Undisciplined Design



Once upon a time

BODIES, ROOMS, MOMENTS, FICTIONS

Welcome to your present life. Where everything that is made can be re-made. All history is Unnatural—as in Synthetic—as in Polyester—as in Elastic. History can be stretched.

History is a copy of a copy of a copy of a copy of a copy of a history that was, from the beginning, a copy of someone's blurry memory.

These stories that I will tell you are slippery and fluid, like the insides of our bodies. Language is slippery and words create worlds. Some words make worlds more convincing. Some people know things. Some people are in doubt.

When you do not want to speak as a 'knower', you talk with a lot of blanks and holes and question marks. Perhaps you have no desire to fix meaning, which may sometimes lead you to a place of nonsense. But, in language, even when you work with nonsense, people find meaning. Nonsense, blanks, holes and gaps could be manifestations of confusion but they also open up to new possibilities if we don't try to fill them with the pre-known and the familiar. — Trinh T. Minh-ha[1]

All of these—my—words are, by definition, limited. They are subjective, situated in time and space, in this particular body, with its own particular slippery history. I speak through a choir of collaborators, friends (Maryam Fanni, Matilda Flodmark, Robynn McPherson, Jessica Gysel, Katja Mater, Marnie Slater, Nicole Killian, and so many more).

It might have been the artist, writer and poet, Elizam Escobar, who said "The struggle is (also) between one fiction and another."

Welcome to the struggle. Welcome to a soup of past and future fictions.

ONCE UPON A TIME, there was something called



"graphic design."

Graphic design was



optimistic,



complicit,
idealistic, naive, narcissistic, confused.

Graphic design was a kind of



"job."

A job was something you did, often in exchange for money, to be able to pay for



things.

Another word for job is "labor." Labor means "work." Work means an activity involving mental or physical effort done in order to achieve a result. A task to be undertaken. A thing to be done.

The things that graphic designers had to do, in exchange for money, was arranging words and images on surfaces.



Codex Seraphinianus
Luigi Serafini, 1981

Money was a system of symbols, invented to move objects and non-objects between people. Humans spent the money they had earned doing things that had to be done, to have a safe place to sleep, to cook, eat and wash. Sometimes they paid for care, medical or emotional. They paid to access



life.

ONCE UPON A TIME, many graphic designers spent much time wanting to understand what they were doing in the world, and why, and for whom. They talked to each other, they wrote books, they gathered in symposia. Some searched for the origin story of graphic design. The creation myth.



Where had graphic design come from and why was it here, and why were they all doing it? They looked into forms, colors and machines, searching for meaning and answers. What was it all for? Sometimes they cried into feeds and platforms. They cried into spines of books and magazines, hiding their despair and confusion behind glossy covers and shiny, foil blocked letters.

Many graphic designers found the Answer in something called



grids.

A grid was an arrangement of lines and measurements, drawn onto a paper sheet or digital sheet. The grid was a savior and a safety net. It lent security and efficiency to the things



that had to be done.

The world leaned back into the grid. Grids were worshipped, replicated, reproduced. Words and letters were sprinkled onto the grid. Many things could be sprinkled onto grids.



Systema Naturae, Carl von Linné, 1735

Flowers,



'The Country's Races' images presented in the shower room of the Swedish State Institute for Racial Biology at the Stockholm Exhibition, 1930

humans,



nature.

ONCE UPON A TIME, grids were considered useful tools to achieve overview, control, order, structure. The result seemed to be a certain kind of readability. Reliability.

As the legend goes, in the middle of the 20th century, a handsome young white man called



Joe
wrote a big, orange

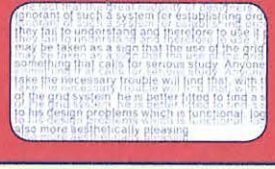


book.

Joe was from a geographical area formerly known as



in what used to be called "Western Europe." For some reason, much of what was considered the Holy Scriptures of Graphic Design had been composed in the ancient kingdoms of this part of the world. Joe was very convincing. He spoke in tongues,



preaching and praying, praising the grid as a safe haven, away from the incomprehensible, the distorted, the queer. Where before there might have been a pile of *stuff*—of words and letters and images, an entangled mess of life—grids created surfaces of order and borders.

The Holy Scriptures of Graphic Design told stories of (men) revolutionizing, changing, pushing the field of graphic design, into new forms, new colors, new ways of gridding. The



spearheads
of the field.

Spearhead is another word for avant-garde, meaning being on the forefront of, meaning being cutting edge, meaning cutting, meaning being a weapon, meaning being at war. Many of the missionaries who believed in saving humanity from illegibility and dangerous dissonance left Europe for North America, where the Holy Scriptures gathered more strength. They brought the canons and built new



canons.

The Holy Scriptures of Graphic Design, along with the words of Joe & the Grids, gathered masses of devoted followers. The followers were called "graphic designers." Some followers came together to form larger gatherings, companies or businesses, also known as



"studios."
Some worked on their own.



Image by @designershumor

Graphic designers set up their places of worship



in many urban centers of the world.

The natural habitat of the graphic designer shared some recurring characteristics. It had what was known as a "desktop computer." There was often a window. There was probably a library of selected Holy Scriptures printed on paper. There were plants and posters. In this "studio," the designer was busy at work. Laboring. Doing the things that had to be done. To get the money. To be able to pay for the food, coffee, plants, books, posters, pants, shoes, tomatoes, travels, bags, beers.

The desktop computer attached to the graphic designer was also known as a "laptop." A laptop was a small metal box—a top for the lap—emitting blue light and containing the tools for doing the things that had to be done. Only one person at a time could labor on the laptop. The work of the designer was tucked away in this small metal box, out of sight, within the warm dark heart of the laptop.

ONCE UPON A TIME, the designer was becoming designer, repeating the choreography of the designer. She was sending designer emails, pushing designer pixels, naming designer files and folders.

In repeating the work of ~~typing~~ designing, my body comes to feel a certain way. My neck gets sore, and I stretch to ease the discomfort. I pull my shoulders back every now and then as the posture I assume (a bad posture I am sure) is a huddle: I huddle over the table as I repeat the action (the banging of keys with the tips of my fingers; the action shapes me, and it leaves its impression through bodily sensations, prickly feelings and the skin surface, and the more intense experience of discomfort. I ~~write~~ design, and, in performing this work, I might yet become my object and become a ~~writer~~ designer, with a ~~writer's~~ designer's body and a ~~writer's~~ designer's tendencies.
— Sara Ahmed[2]
(quote edited by Sara Kaaman)

As a part of her daily practice, the graphic designer performed many rituals. A ritual is *a ceremony consisting of a series of actions performed according to a prescribed order*. One of these rituals was called



"social media."
The social media ritual involved rapid meditation on JPEGs, GIFs and moving images, using your fingers you smeared them across the surface of your ritualistic device. The purpose of this ritual was to blur the boundaries between Connection and Disconnection and Intimacy and Privacy and Promotion.

ONCE UPON A TIME, we showed much ~~tenderness~~ and care towards our technological devices and extensions.

ONCE UPON A TIME, we had eyes. ~~We~~ used them to discriminate and divide. We used them to read illuminated squares on a grid. We used them to discern ourselves from others. We used them to determine the value of everything: beautiful from ugly from cool from boring from stunning from nice.

ONCE UPON A TIME, the graphic designer was convinced that she could find community and companionship in competition. Sometimes by actually, literally, competing in competitions where products of her labor would compete against the labor of others.

Design competitions, book competitions, poster competitions, gender design competitions. A competition is: *the activity or condition of striving to gain or win something by defeating or establishing superiority over others.*

ONCE UPON A TIME, the graphic designer was convinced that her individual creativity and success would lead to happiness. Being an individual felt exciting. It felt like



freedom.

Freedom was invented in the early 1400s. It was given away for free to some humans. Others received no freedom.

ONCE UPON A TIME, there were no graphic designers.

This



is a photograph of five women, in 1873, working at a printing office in Stockholm, Sweden. They're wearing black dresses and white aprons, dirty from the lead dust. Their work involves heavy metal. They work with typography.

This



is a photograph from a meeting of the Swedish Association for Typographers, on March 7, 1874. A union is: *a society or association formed by people with a common interest or purpose.*

Around the world, printers and typesetters were among the first professions to create unions. The first workers' association in Sweden was the



Swedish Association for Typographers (formed in 1846). On March 7, 1874, a member of the organization submits a proposal to allow typographers and typesetters of the female gender to join. The proposal is denied by a voting majority, the vote is accompanied by anger and laughter.

This



is a photograph from the next meeting, on April 11, 1874. Another member insists that nowhere in the regulations is male gender mentioned as a requirement for membership. The head of the organization replies that it is, of course, not necessary to state the obvious—that, of course, no women could be considered typesetters, even if they worked as such. Several other meetings and heated discussions follow where the men-members worry about typesetting jeopardizing the health of the women, about women dumping the salaries, about women not being fit for the work. It takes 14 years of processing the idea. On March 3, 1888, the first five female members join the organization.

This



is a photograph of six women around a table, another 16 years later, in 1904. They're not working, they're organizing. They have formed Typografiska Kvinnoklubben (Women's Typographic Association). Even though they are welcome as members of the national union, they see their specific struggles undermined by their male comrades. In the Women's Typographic Association, they organize to confront further allegations of women's lesser value and skill as typographers—within the union as well as in public debates and in the newspapers.

This



is Beatrice Warde in 1925.

You might have heard about her. Beatrice Warde was a writer and researcher on typography. She worked as a marketing manager for the Monotype Corporation. She also wrote about typography. Her most famous text is titled 'The Crystal Goblet, or Printing Should Be Invisible.' This text has become a staple in graphic design education worldwide, forcing many a graphic design student to look up the word



goblet.

In 1959, Beatrice Warde is interviewed about her life and practice and says:

> Printing trade is barred to women, on the craftsman level. You can't be apprenticed to the printing trade if you're a woman, except in certain forms like binding and all that, and that's been true for many centuries.[3]

From Warde's position and situated knowledge—probably from her reading of the histories that were available to her—this was a truth. It gives the impression that, according to Warde, women have been absent from printing for many centuries.

But—



Members of the Women's Typographic Association in 1925

take a look at the struggles of the many women in typography during the 20th century, along with the words of Warde in 1959. Remember how easy it is to write a version of history—a kind of fiction—that reproduces someone's blind spots, and then, through repetition, becomes a fact. Remember how easy it is to listen to the singular voices, the simple stories—one woman's voice. Because this one voice might be clearer, easier to make out. It is, most probably, more easily available. Remember how easy it is to not hear the words of choirs and masses, because they speak over and through each other. Annoying, too loud, too messy. Remember how easily we all look in the same corners of history, finding the same names, the same narratives.

Often, the stories that we find—or look for—happen to match quite well with a contemporary understanding of what a "graphic designer" looks like. One individual, working alone, "breaking ground," "pushing the field."

All this is to say that a female historiography is not necessarily a feminist historiography. And a feminist historiography is not necessarily an intersectional historiography. And the way we write history today affects the way we imagine the field of graphic design tomorrow.

Some words are less legible, some stories are less legible, some people are less legible. In the words of writer and artist Litia Perta:

> unintelligibility is the risk and it is also the promise. Because what does it mean when you're not understood but that somehow the system cannot hear you see you hold you? that the things that have been legible you have somehow exceeded or undone, fallen underneath the radar of the readable or were not written into the laws of legibility to begin with? and so legibility cannot be all there is and so it can't be all there is to work toward, may even be what we need to work against.[4]

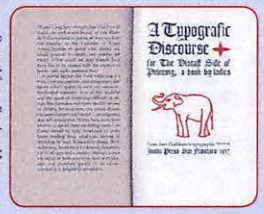
Who reads you? Who do you read?
Are you readable?
What are you looking at?
Do you like friction?

ONCE UPON A TIME, in 1937, in San Francisco, there was an elephant called



Jumbo.

Jumbo belonged to Jane Grabhorn. Jumbo was a printing press and Jane Grabhorn was a typesetter, writer and designer. Among many other things, she wrote three tenets—rules—of typography.



Spread from *Bookmaking on the Distaff Side*, 1937

The first one goes like this:

Do not hyphenate your words. This is not because the effect thus achieved is novel and there-by striking in appearance, but because of the beautiful logic of such procedure.

Consider these things ladies, and allow those qualities so peculiar to the female courage, imaginativeness, adaptability & the will to experiment, Oh give them their head and let the results be caustic spangled pages of type shot thru the heavens of paper and ink.[5]

This text, and Jane Grabhorn, is one of about 20 contributions in a book called *Bookmaking on the Distaff Side* that was published in 1937 in San Francisco. "Distaff" is an Old English term denoting "the female sphere" and the work is a potluck in the form of a book, featuring female bookmakers, printers, typographers, illustrators, proofreaders, bibliophiles, type designers, et cetera.

In the writing of Jane Grabhorn, the body is present in the way these hyphens, which she proposes we get rid of, are bodies of lead. They are inserted by *hand*. The body is present in how she asks us, readers, to

END OF TENET NUMBER TWO give thanks & take a deep breath

give thanks and take a deep breath.

Jane Grabhorn also wrote:

I am not what is commonly known as a "designer" and have always been a little contemptuous of people who call themselves "designers", who seem to think this is more artistic and do not want to be thought of as lowly labourers.[6]

ONCE UPON A TIME, in 1986, Macintosh launched a machine called



"Macintosh Plus."

ONCE UPON A TIME, in 1986, the media tycoon Rupert Murdoch fired 6,000 print workers who worked on newspaper production in London. In secret, he had built a brand-new printing plant with all the newest technology. Using modern computer technology, journalists would be able to input copy directly for printing, and the typesetters were made redundant.



Protest poster by Morning Star Poster, 1986.

By hiring electricians to run the printing presses, he was able to bypass the strong unions of typographers and printers. In 1986, 6,000 unionized print-workers went on a strike that would last over a year.

ONCE UPON A TIME, in 1987, the first version of the predecessor to Adobe InDesign, called PageMaker, was shipped with Macintosh Plus. Gail Cartmail, who worked at a printing house at this time, says:

At the time the technology was overtaking the whole industry, and in the union there was a real struggle between conventional and new technology. We were slow to realise that we would have to embrace unionising and technology. There is a lesson here for us today with automation. The organisation became much poorer and the least organised area is in the graphic area, partly because it became individualised. Every graphic designer I know is a freelancer; it is not a collective environment. ... When I was in the industry ... Everybody was working as a part of a bigger company; the minute you are breaking that up, working for yourself, you become vulnerable.[7]

In February of 1987, the strike, known as the *Wapping dispute*, collapsed. Around the same time restrictive policies against unions were introduced by the government led by Margaret Thatcher. Enter "desktop publishing." A desktop holds one laptop, one coffee cup, one lamp, one person.

ONCE UPON A TIME, Britney Spears sang a swan song to the shrinking strength of unionizing:

My loneliness
Is killing me
And I must confess
I still believe (still believe)
When I'm not with you
I lose my mind
... How was I supposed to know?
I shouldn't have let you go[8]

When you are alone, on your couch, in your studio, working happily away on your metal box, do you know which rooms, historical spaces, bodies, struggles that you are connected to? Do you know where they come from; the physical and mental walls and ceilings of our screens, sheets, interfaces, studios, couches, cafés, offices?

If we would look more closely at how these rooms have morphed and changed through time—from factory-like typesetting workshops to the softly camouflaged factory of the laptop—can we understand our current rooms, our current postures? Can we see how spaces and technologies shape our imagination and the ways we work?

And if our rooms are still, *now*, changing, moving, possibly shrinking, is that happening in a way that supports disobedient practices of graphic design?

These stories we tell ourselves about what we do,
and why we do it,
and who did it before,
and why we don't do it,
and how we don't do it,
these stories become truths.
Can we imagine a different professional identity? One built on collectivity and community? Can we try to name and understand our material working conditions? What if we can see how we are entangled and dependent, and that we will never be able to find community in competition?

Graphic designer Ramon Tejada writes:

DESIGN needs to be more open, more fluid, have more holes, literally, and conceptually. ...



More surreal, magical, absurdist. Less hierarchical (or at least single hierarchy and more about multiple hierarchies).

Leave room space.

Be more porous, less controlled, less about organization (organization for whom? And by whom?). What does this mean and how do we

each individually make it happen? ... PUNCTURE: an act of puncturing a hole, wound or perforation made by puncturing a minute depression. ...

GET OUT OF THE WAY,
MAKE SPACE, STOP HUGGING SO MUCH OF THE FIELD (THE HISTORY).
MAKE ROOM.

Puncturing as a methodology is about redefining, digging, finding, thinking, ideating, making and probably having to remake and start again. It is about not being afraid, and about getting messy and resisting the reflex of our processes and knowledge. It is about saying, "I don't know it all, and I need to learn more, differently".

Puncturing is about thinking how we design (both the structural, formal, and conceptual form it takes) platforms and spaces that allow for excluded voices to come through. How we cede that spotlight. How we take our personal and DESIGN ego out of the way.
...

LET'S COLLECTIVELY PUNCTURE
AND STIR THE POT.

LET THE FLOODGATES GO.[9]

ONCE UPON A TIME, there was a symposium on graphic design in a town called Leipzig in a country called Germany.

The collective body was awakened.

Individualism was a mistake.

Individualism was a mistake.

Individualism was a mistake.

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2) Ahmed, S. (2006) *Queer Phenomenology – Orientations, Objects, Others,* Durham: Duke University Press, 57.

3) de Bondt, S. (2012) 'Beatrice Warde: Manners and Type', *Eye Magazine* 84 (21). Via: http://www.eyemagazine.com/feature/article/beatrice-warde-manners-and-type

4) Perta, L. (2015) 'AGAINST CURATION OR LOSING YOUR GRIP'. Via: http://www.litiaperta.com/writingbodies

5) Grabhorn, J. (1937) 'A Typographic Discourse for The Distaff Side of Printing, a Book by Ladies', *Bookmaking on the Distaff Side*, San Francisco: Distaff Side.

6) Rather, C. & Rather, L. (1975) *Jane Grabhorn, Printer,* Oakland, California: Rather Press, 19–20.

7) Fanni, M. et al (2020) 'Excerpt from a conversation with Gail Cartmail', *Natural Enemies of Books—A Messy History of Women in Printing and Typography*, Fanni, M., Flodmark, M. & Kaaman, S., eds. London: Occasional Papers, 153.

8) Martin, M. (lyrics) & Spears, B. (singer) (1998) 'Baby One More Time'

9) Tejada, R. (2019) 'Decolonizing DESIGN a sermon on the hierarchy of design', *Amalgam Journal* 2, Pouya Ahmadi, ed.

Typefaces: Times Dot by Laurel Schwulst. Xirwena by Pia Frauss. SimSun by Beijing ZhongYi Electronics Co.

R for
Role Play
Role Play
Role Play
Role Play

As designers,
As *female designers in the extended field of design,*
As designers-cum-artists,
As conflicted role-models,

we naturally wear many hats and multitask a variety of roles.
we naturally wear many hats and multitask a variety of roles.
one is quickly suspected of lacking "expert knowledge."
for the emotional carnage that is cultural work in late capitalism.

